

You'll see a lot of cables running all over the place, stuck on one end to various devices, with the other ends attached to a common board. This is the biggest circuit board inside the case, and is called the motherboard. It has various types of slots on it, and also houses the CPU and the RAM modules. We'll get to these a little later; the part we are concerned about right now is the CPU.

A CPU upgrade is generally necessary when you try installing applications and games and they don't work properly—or give too many errors, or crash frequently. This is due to insufficient processing power.

Before you start tugging at the heat-sink of the CPU, let's go through a small checklist that will prevent you from damaging the CPU. First of all, make sure you have enough room to work with the CPU without any obstructions, most notably the power supply and the add-on cards on the motherboard. If anything is causing an obstruction, remove it gently. If the RAM modules are coming in the way, remove them by pushing the little levers on both sides of the slot. This will make the RAM module pop up. Before you remove the module, note the manner in which it was inserted, so you can put it back in the right way. (You shouldn't try and push it in the wrong way; there's only one direction in which it will fit.)

Removing the power supply is pretty easy—all you have to do is disconnect all power cables connected to all devices inside the cabinet, including the motherboard, and then remove the screws on the back of the tower that go into the power supply. Then gently slide the power supply out of the cabinet.

For add-on cards such as an internal modem or a video card that may be obstructing your view of the CPU, remove the screw on the back panel that attaches it to the tower, and then remove it gently by pulling it out of the slot. In case of video cards that are plugged into an AGP slot, check for a small lever that acts as a lock before trying to remove the card. Once you have taken all these